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J-1 Visa Information

Dear Student,

Now that you have received your Form DS-2019 or "Certificate of Eligibility for Exchange Visitor (J-1) Status," as well as your Form I-901 SEVIS Fee Payment Confirmation, you are ready to apply for your J-1 Visa. You must submit both forms to your U.S. embassy or consulate in order to apply for your J-1 Visa.

We strongly recommend that you begin your visa application as soon as possible. Please note that you alone are responsible for applying for your J-1 Visa. To help you with your application, we have put together some general information and advice about the application process. Read all information carefully before submitting your application. Any mistake could delay your application or even cause it to be rejected.

Some of the information in this booklet may have changed since it was last updated. You should check the official website of the U.S. embassy or consulate where you will apply for your visa for the newest information. Any information you find on the website takes the place of the information in this booklet. You should also let your NWSE Program Coordinator know immediately if you find any old or incorrect information in this booklet.

If you have any questions, contact us at any time. We look forward to welcoming you to the U.S.!

Your NWSE Team

The Visa Application Process

Step 1: Where and when to apply?

- Go to the website of the U.S. embassy in your country to find out which U.S. embassy or consulate you need to go to in order to apply for your J-1 Visa. In most countries, the place you live in will determine which U.S. embassy or consulate you need to go to. Sometimes a country has multiple consulates, but please note that not every U.S. consulate handles visa applications.
- Although it is possible to apply for your visa at a U.S. embassy or consulate outside of your home country, we recommend you apply in your home country, because your chances of success will probably be higher.
- You must schedule an interview at your U.S. embassy or consulate and submit your visa application documents in person. Follow the exact instructions on the website of your U.S. embassy or consulate to schedule an appointment for your interview and submit your documents.
- You should apply for your J-1 Visa long before the date you plan to travel to the U.S. in order to avoid delays. You can check the current wait times for J-1 Visa interview appointments at https://travel.state.gov/content/visas/en/general/wait-times.html/.

Step 2: Prepare a photo for your visa application

- To complete the visa application (see Step 3 below), you must upload a digital passport-style photo of yourself. It is helpful to prepare it ahead of time. The requirements for this digital photo are described in the websites below. Your photo must meet these requirements **exactly**.
  - Photo Requirements: https://travel.state.gov/content/visas/en/general/photos.html
  - Digital Image Requirements: https://travel.state.gov/content/visas/en/general/photos/digital-image-requirements.html
- Check the website of the U.S. embassy or consulate where you plan to apply for your J-1 Visa. They may require you to bring a printed passport-style photo to the interview. If so, make sure that your photo meets their requirements **exactly**.

Step 3: Complete the Nonimmigrant Visa Application Form DS-160

- Before you schedule your visa appointment, you are required to complete the Online Nonimmigrant Visa Application (Form DS-160). To start Form DS-160, go to the website of the Consular Electronic Application Center at **https://ceac.state.gov/genniv/**.
- After completing Form DS-160 online, you will be directed to a confirmation page, which you must print out and bring to your interview at the U.S. embassy or consulate. You will also need this confirmation page to schedule the appointment for your visa application.

Helpful Tips for Completing Form DS-160

- Save your **Application ID**. You will need this in order to log in again if you have to finish the application at a later time. You can print it by clicking **Print Application ID** on the start page of the application.
- Always click **Save** after completing each page. After 20 minutes of inactivity, you will automatically be logged out of your application, and you will lose any unsaved information.
- Find **Select Tooltip Language** at the top right-hand corner of the page and choose your native language. If you hold the mouse over a word or sentence, a translation of it will appear in your native language.

Enter the information as follows:

- Personal Information 1:
  - Note: Your contact information must match what is written on your passport exactly.
  - If your name on your passport is not written in the Latin alphabet, there is an option to enter it in your native alphabet. Otherwise, check **Does Not Apply/Technology Not Available**.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Personal Information 2:
  - National Identification Number: If your government does not issue national ID numbers (equivalent to the U.S. Social Security Number), check **Does Not Apply** for all three identification numbers.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Address and Phone Information:
  - Enter your home address, mailing address, primary phone number, and e-mail address.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Passport:
  - Passport/Travel Document Type: Select **Regular**, unless there is a different option that applies to you.
  - Passport/Travel Document Number: Double-check that you entered your passport number correctly.
  - Use the information in your passport to fill out the remaining questions.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Travel Information:
  - Purpose of Trip to the U.S.: **Exchange Visitor (J)**
  - Specify: **Student (J1)**
  - Intended Date of Arrival:
    - If you already have booked your flights, enter your scheduled date of arrival.
    - If you have not yet received your placement information or booked your flights, enter the program start date in Box 3 of your Form DS-2019.
  - Intended Length of Stay in U.S.:
    - Academic year program: **10 MONTHS**
    - Semester program: **5 MONTHS**
  - Address Where You Will Stay in the U.S.:
    - If you have already been placed with a host family, enter their home address.
    - If you have not yet been placed with a host family, enter the following:
      - Street Address (Line 1): **3302 FUHRMAN AVE, SUITE 300**
      - City: **SEATTLE**
      - State: **WASHINGTON**
      - ZIP Code: **98102**
  - Person/Entity Paying for Your Trip:
    - If your parents or other family members are paying your fees, select **SELF**.
    - If you received a scholarship, enter the contact information of the foundation or organization that gave you the scholarship.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Travel Companion Information:
  - Select **No**.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Previous U.S. Travel Information:
  - Enter the dates of any previous trips to the U.S.
  - If you answer “Yes” to any remaining questions, inform NWSE immediately.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- U.S. Point of Contact Information:
  - Enter the name and contact information for the NWSE Responsible Officer:
    - Surnames: **BROLL**
    - Given Names: **DENNIS**
    - Organization Name: **NORTHWEST STUDENT EXCHANGE**
    - U.S. Street Address (Line 1): **3302 FUHRMAN AVE, SUITE 300**
    - City: **SEATTLE**
    - State: **WASHINGTON**
    - ZIP Code: **98102**
    - Phone Number: **2065270917**
    - Email Address: **nwse@nwse.com**
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Family Information: Relatives:
  - Enter the contact information of your biological father and mother. If you have had no contact with one of your biological parents and were raised instead by a step-parent, enter the name of your step-parent. If you were adopted, enter the names of your adoptive parents.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Present Work/Education/Training Information:
  - Primary Occupation: **STUDENT**
  - Enter the contact information of your high school in your home country.
  - Monthly Income in Local Currency (if employed): **Does Not Apply**
  - Briefly describe your duties: **COMPLETE SCHOOL WORK**
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Previous Work/Education/Training Information:
  - Were you previously employed? **No**
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Security and Background: Parts 1-5:
  - You should answer **NO** to all questions. If you need to answer **YES** to any question, inform your NWSE Program Coordinator immediately.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Additional Point of Contact Information:
  - Give the contact information of two individuals who live in your home country and can verify that the information you gave is correct. You can use friends, acquaintances, neighbors, or a local agent or coordinator from your exchange organization. You cannot use family members.
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- SEVIS Information:
  - SEVIS ID: This number is located at the upper right-hand corner of your Form DS-2019 and begins with **N**.
  - Program Number: **P-3-05374**
  - Do you intend to study in the U.S.? **Yes**
  - If NWSE has already notified you of your school placement, enter the name and address of your school. If you have not yet been placed in a U.S. school, enter the name and address of NorthWest Student Exchange (as given on the U.S. Point of Contact Information page).
  - Course of Study: **Academic**
  - Click **Save**, then **Continue Application**.

- Upload Photo:
  - Upload the passport-style photo that you prepared in Step 2.

- Review:
  - Check that all of the information that you entered is correct.
  - To sign your application electronically, enter your **passport number** and the CAPTCHA numerical code.

- Confirmation:
  - **Print** out the confirmation page. You must bring this confirmation page with you to your visa interview appointment at your U.S. embassy or consulate.

Step 4: Schedule an appointment

- Now that you have completed your visa application, the next step is to schedule your visa interview appointment and pay your visa application fee. In order to do this, go to the website of the Visa Service Provider at **www.ustraveldocs.com**. There you will select your country, and then it will send you to **https://cgifederal.secure.force.com/** where you will create a user account.
- Follow the instructions to schedule an interview appointment and pay your visa application fee. As you go through the website, choose "nonimmigrant visa," then "Students and Exchange Visitors (F,M,J)," and then "J-1 - Exchange Visitor."
- Additional information in your native language can be found on the website of your U.S. embassy or consulate.
- You can check the visa processing and wait times for your U.S. embassy or consulate at https://travel.state.gov/content/visas/en/general/wait-times.html/
- Most U.S. embassy or consulates require the following things when you schedule your appointment:
  - Passport Information: This includes your passport number, issuance date, issuance place, expiration date.
  - DS-160 Confirmation Number: See Step 3 above for detailed instructions.
  - SEVIS Number: You can find this number in the upper right-hand corner of your Form DS-2019. The number follows the letter "N."
  - Program Number: The program number for NWSE is **P-3-05374**.
- Pay the J-1 Visa Application Fee: Follow the instructions in your CGI Federal account to pay the non-refundable J-1 Visa application fee. Print out the receipt as proof of your payment. Please note that the J-1 Visa application fee is different from the SEVIS fee, which NWSE has already paid for you, as confirmed on the enclosed Form I-901.
- After you have scheduled your J-1 Visa appointment, print out the appointment confirmation page. You must bring a printed copy of the confirmation when you go to the U.S. embassy or consulate for your visa application. (See Step 5 below.)

Step 5: Prepare your application materials

- **Make a checklist:** Write down all the documents and materials the U.S. embassy or consulate requires you to bring for your J-1 Visa application. These materials can be different from country to country, but the following items are the most common:
  - **Form DS-2019:** You must bring the *original* double-sided Form DS-2019 ("Certificate of Eligibility") that NWSE mailed to you. Do *not* use the scanned copy. Sign the bottom of your DS-2019, enter the place (city and country) where you signed, and the date of your signature.
  - **Form DS-160:** You must bring a print-out of the confirmation page you see after submitting Form DS-160 online. See "Step 3: Complete the Nonimmigrant Visa Application Form DS-160" above for more information.
  - **Form I-901:** You must bring Form I-901 (SEVIS fee payment receipt) that NWSE sent to you.
  - **Valid passport:** You must also bring a valid passport. If you have a passport from one of the countries on the PDF document at https://www.cbp.gov/document/bulletins/six-month-club-update, the expiration date must only be valid until after the date you expect to return to your home country. For all other countries, the expiration date must be at least six months after the

date you expect to return. National identity cards or child passports are not accepted. The U.S. embassy or consulate will keep your passport and return it to you by mail after processing your J-1 Visa application.

- **A printed copy of your J-1 Visa application appointment confirmation** for the U.S. embassy or consulate where you are submitting your application.
- **Additional required documents:** Check the website of the specific U.S. embassy or consulate where you plan to apply (http://usembassy.state.gov) for information about any other documents that you may need to have in order to apply.
- **Supporting documents:**
  In addition to the *required* J-1 Visa application documents, you may also want to submit *supporting* documents to show that you meet the criteria for J-1 Visa holders. This may improve your chances of success with your interview. See "General Criteria for J-1 Visa Applicants" below for helpful information about supporting documents.

- **IMPORTANT**: Save copies of all your visa application documents before you give them to the embassy or consulate.

General Criteria for J-1 Visa Applicants

To qualify for the J-1 Visa, you must be able to prove the following to the consular officer:

1) You have enough money to cover your costs during your exchange in the U.S.
2) You have good reasons to return to your home country after your exchange program.
3) You know enough English to attend a U.S. high school.

1) Financial Resources

Check the number in Box 5 of your Form DS-2019 to see the minimum amount of money that you must have in order to cover for your costs during your exchange program. The consular officer may ask you to prove that you have this money available for your exchange.

One way to prove this is to give the officer (1) a *bank statement* that shows that there is much more money in your bank account than the number in Box 5; and (2) a signed and dated letter from the holders of the bank account (e.g., your parents) that officially says that they will cover all your personal costs during your stay in the U.S.

If you are still not sure how to prove that you have enough money, we suggest that you contact your U.S. embassy or consulate before your appointment and ask them which documents they accept.

2) Motivation to Return to your Home Country

Because the J-1 Visa is a non-immigrant visa, the consular officer may ask you to prove that you intend to return to your home country after the exchange and will not try to stay in the U.S. illegally. There are no specific rules about what kind of proof they will accept. You should simply do your best to show that this exchange will help you with your future life in your home country.

To explain how the exchange will help you in your home country, it may be a good idea to write a letter to the consular officer in which you say specifically how the experience and skills you will gain from the exchange will help you with your future educational and work plans in your home country.

Consular officers sometimes ask *indirect* questions to find out if a student will try to stay in the U.S. For example, if you say that you plan to go to a U.S. university after your exchange, that you have relatives

in the U.S., or that you want to work in the U.S., the officer may think that you do not want to return to your home country.

If an EducationUSA Advising Center has recommended you for the exchange, a letter of recommendation from them may also help with this part of your application.

3) English Skills

Although NWSE has already tested your English, the consular officer may want to test your knowledge of English as well. In general, if you can understand the basic meaning of the officer's questions and answer appropriately, you should not have any problems.

If you are worried that your English is not good enough, you could give the officer a copy of the results from your English proficiency test (e.g., ELTiS or TOEFL), if you have taken one.* You should also give the officer an explanation of the test results (e.g., your *percentile ranking*, which shows the percentage of test takers whose results were lower than yours) in order to help the officer understand your test results. In general, NWSE exchange students do not have any problems with proving that their English is good enough.

> * If you have not taken an English proficiency test, do not worry. Not every NWSE student must take this test. If you have not taken one, then you did not have to do it.

Step 6: Go to your interview

- Now it is time for your appointment at the U.S. embassy or consulate. Put all of your documents in order, and plan to arrive early to your appointment.
- There are certain things that you cannot bring into the building, such as electronic devices (e.g., mobile phones), sharp objects (e.g., pocket knives), and/or large bags. For more information, check your appointment confirmation, as well as the website of the U.S. embassy or consulate.
- Contact NWSE *immediately* if the U.S. embassy or consulate informs you that they have denied your application for the J-1 Visa.

Good luck with your application!

Entering the U.S.

- After you have received your J-1 Visa, you may enter the U.S. as an exchange student. The U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Service (USCIS) allows J-1 Visa holders to enter the U.S. up to 29 days before the program start date (see Box 3 of your Form DS-2019).
- **Read the enclosed info sheet "Arrival Procedures for Exchange Visitors or Students" carefully.** You can find further useful information about traveling, maintaining your J-1 Visa status, and other topics at https://j1visa.state.gov/participants/.
- Be sure to go through the "Packing List" that NWSE provides to ensure you do not forget anything when you travel to the U.S.
- Once you arrive at a U.S. airport, you will receive an admission stamp in your passport from the U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officer. The stamp proves your legal status in the U.S. NWSE recommends that you look at the stamp as soon as the immigration officer returns the passport to you. If the stamp does not show the entry as *J-1*; or if the "until" date is not *D/S* (duration of stay), or if the "until" date is before your last day of school in the U.S., you should

politely ask the immigration officer about this. If you notice a mistake after you leave the airport, contact NWSE immediately. You can also check your arrival and departure records online at www.cbp.gov/I94.

- If you enter the U.S. by land from Canada or Mexico, you will also receive a pre-completed Form I-94 (a postcard-sized, white form) from the U.S. Customs and Border Protection (CBP) officer. Be sure to keep the Form I-94 in your passport at all times. When you leave the U.S., an immigration officer or airline staff member will remove this form as record of your departure.
- After you arrive in the U.S., make copies of your passport, J-1 Visa, and passport stamp (and Form I-94 if you arrived by land from Mexico or Canada), and keep them in a safe place that is separate from your passport.

Leaving the U.S.

- You may stay in the U.S. for a maximum of 29 days after the official end date of your exchange program. During this time, called the “grace period,” you are no longer in J-1 Visa status.
- The official end date of your exchange program is typically the last day you are expected to attend your U.S. high school. It is listed in the most recent Placement Notification Form you received from NWSE (unless otherwise confirmed by NWSE). If you are not sure about the official end date of your exchange program, contact the NWSE office.
- You and your natural parents should agree with your host family on a date for your departure from their house (and the U.S.), and then immediately send NWSE or the NWSE partner organization in your home country a copy of the itinerary for your return flight.
- If you would like to travel within the U.S. after you leave your host family’s house, inform NWSE of your travel plans long before you make any arrangements.
- The U.S. Department of State strongly discourages trips outside the U.S. during your 29-day grace period. Students who try to re-enter the U.S. during this time cannot use their J-1 Visa to do so. You might also not be allowed to do so on a Visa Waiver (with ESTA registration) or a Visitor Visa.